

Top 9 Web Design Trends of 2026

PHASE 1: Introduction

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [spoken_transcript] In this video, I'm breaking down the top nine web design trends of 2026.
- [on_screen_text] 2026 TRENDS
- [spoken_transcript] I've been tracking hundreds of websites, and there are some real clear patterns that are starting to show up.
- [on_screen_text] REAL CLEAR PATTERNS
- [spoken_transcript] So if you want your sites to stand out this next year, you're going to want to watch this one. Are you ready? Let's go.

PHASE 2: Trend #1 — Barely There UI

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [on_screen_text] Trend #1
- [spoken_transcript] This first trend is happening because of where the money is flowing.
- [spoken_transcript] Venture capital is pouring into AI companies. And every new startup wants to look like they belong in that club. So, designers are naturally copying the big AI players. And companies like OpenAI and Perplexity, who are the big AI players, have gone hyper minimal.
- [on_screen_text] www.openai.com
- [spoken_transcript] Everyone else is just kind of following suit. And I don't think money is going to be diverted from AI opportunities anytime soon, so this trend will definitely be extending into 2026 and probably get even more widely used as time goes on.
- [on_screen_text] BARELY THERE UI
- [spoken_transcript] I'm calling it the barely there UI.
- [spoken_transcript] And with it, you're going to see a lot of really skinny sans serifs, some stripped-down layouts, and color palettes that are really dialed back.
- [on_screen_text] 1. Skinny Sans Serifs
- [on_screen_text] 2. Simple Layouts & Color Palettes
- [spoken_transcript] Now, in some cases, there's a bit more going on with images and graphic elements, but it's still pretty reserved.
- [on_screen_text] 3. Minimal Graphic Design
- [spoken_transcript] One thing that they're definitely not afraid to display are graphs.
- [on_screen_text] 4. Graphs
- [spoken_transcript] They're putting graphs absolutely everywhere.
- [spoken_transcript] If you want to try out this first trend, you you gotta ask yourself, does this fit in to the overall brand of the business and the goal of the website?
- [on_screen_text] Does this fit the brand and goal of the site that I'm working on?
- [spoken_transcript] And that's really true for every trend that I'm going to be talking about today. But if it fits, don't be afraid to dial back the amount of colors in a color palette. And

and don't feel like you gotta have more than just one font family. That's all that you really need. And, of course, dial up the white space.

- [spoken_transcript] I actually love this trend, and I love the fact that it's growing in popularity. I'm excited to see how it takes shape in this next year.

PHASE 3: Trend #2 — Maximalism*

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [on_screen_text] Trend #2
- [spoken_transcript] As we all know, in most creative fields, there's always a reaction to trends that are kind of like the antithesis of what's popular. So, our next trend actually leans a bit in the opposite direction of the barely there UI trend.
- [on_screen_text] 1 Playful
- [on_screen_text] 2 Creative
- [on_screen_text] 3 Confusing?
- [spoken_transcript] It's playful, super creative, and sometimes downright confusing.
- [on_screen_text] MAXIMALISM*
- [spoken_transcript] I'm calling it maximalism with an asterisk.
- [spoken_transcript] And why the asterisk? Well, I thought maximalism would explode this year and even go on into 2026. I expected bigger brands to kind of loosen up, push some bold visuals, and maybe add a little chaos to their sites. But that didn't really happen. And it looks like the AI hyper minimalism just kind of toned everything down. So, maximalism is here. It's just pumped the brakes a bit.
- [spoken_transcript] With this one, you're going to see big bold fonts, bright colors, and in some extreme cases, way too many moving parts on any one webpage.
- [on_screen_text] 1. Big Bold Fonts
- [on_screen_text] 2. Bright Colors
- [on_screen_text] 3. Absolute Chaos
- [spoken_transcript] I think most folks are probably going to dial it back a bit from that. But this is a trend I think that will continue to see in 2026.
- [spoken_transcript] If you want to try this one out, start with making your header fonts a bit bigger than you'd normally feel comfortable. Add a pop of color that stands out from the rest of the palette. Push the limits, but do it in the context of what serves the website and the brand the best.

PHASE 4: Trend #3 — Human Touch / Wabi-Sabi

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [on_screen_text] Trend #3
- [spoken_transcript] As AI continues to become a very real mainstay, this next trend is doing what it can to kind of push back against that.
- [spoken_transcript] Have you heard of the Japanese aesthetic philosophy called Wabi-Sabi?
- [on_screen_text] Wabi-Sabi

- [spoken_transcript] It's the idea that imperfections actually add beauty rather than take away.
- [on_screen_text] IMPERFECTIONS + BEAUTY
- [spoken_transcript] You'll see it in their ceramics, their their gardens, and in other forms of art. And the goal is to find a unique quality that makes that piece one in a million or altogether irreplaceable.
- [on_screen_text] Unique
- [spoken_transcript] And this next year, web designers are going to follow suit. They're going to avoid anything that feels AI generated by adding a little bit of what I'm calling the human touch.
- [on_screen_text] HUMAN TOUCH
- [spoken_transcript] And sometimes it's super subtle. Maybe hand-drawn arrows or or messy underlines under text.
- [on_screen_text] 1. Handdrawn Elements
- [spoken_transcript] But it could also show up as photos that look unpolished or maybe shot on a phone.
- [on_screen_text] 2. Unpolished Images
- [spoken_transcript] Textures that feel handmade like paper or ink.
- [on_screen_text] 3. Handmade Textures
- [spoken_transcript] Illustrations that look like someone sketched them during a meeting.
- [on_screen_text] 4. Simple Illustrations
- [spoken_transcript] It's anything that signals, hey, a real person touched this.
- [spoken_transcript] In some extreme cases, it looks like something I'm calling anti-UX.
- [on_screen_text] ANTI UX
- [spoken_transcript] Anti-UX is another response to the obsession to make everything intuitive and perfect.
- [spoken_transcript] Not everyone's going to get that crazy. In fact, most websites just tend to kind of sprinkle in a bit of super creative somewhat non-intuitive elements. But it's definitely noticeable.
- [spoken_transcript] If you want to try this on your own site, add one or two imperfect handmade elements. A scribble, a rough icon, a little bit of texture.

PHASE 5: Trend #4 — Grade School Color Palettes

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [on_screen_text] Trend #4
- [on_screen_text] Bright Colors in 24/25
- [on_screen_text] GRADE SCHOOL COLOR PALETTES
- [on_screen_text] 1. Crayon Box Colors
- [on_screen_text] 2. Unique Hues, Tints, Tones, & Shades

PHASE 6: Trend #5 — Spaceship Instruction Manual

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [on_screen_text] Trend #5

- [on_screen_text] SPACESHIP INSTRUCTION MANUAL
- [on_screen_text] 1. Blueprint Layout
- [on_screen_text] 2. Lots of Lines
- [on_screen_text] 3. Miscellaneous Labels
- [on_screen_text] 4. Lofi Outlined Images
- [on_screen_text] 4. Monospace Like Fonts

PHASE 7: Trend #6 — Democratized Fancy Animations

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [on_screen_text] Trend #6
- [on_screen_text] DEMOCRATIZED FANCY ANIMATIONS
- [on_screen_text] Spline
- [on_screen_text] Unicorn Studio
- [on_screen_text] Rive
- [on_screen_text] WebGL
- [on_screen_text] 1. Immersive Experiences
- [on_screen_text] 2. Storytelling
- [on_screen_text] Just because you CAN do something doesn't mean you should_
- [on_screen_text] STAND OUT & GET NOTICED

PHASE 8: Trend #7 — Internet Nostalgia

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [on_screen_text] Trend #7
- [on_screen_text] INTERNET NOSTALGIA
- [on_screen_text] 1. Cursor Alternatives
- [on_screen_text] 2. Early Internet UI
- [on_screen_text] 3. ASCII Images
- [on_screen_text] 4. Old Computer Experiences

PHASE 9: Trend #8 — The Tab That's Playing Music

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [on_screen_text] Trend #8
- [on_screen_text] My brain is like my internet browser. 19 tabs are open...3 are frozen and I have no clue where the music is coming from.
- [on_screen_text] THE TAB THAT'S PLAYING MUSIC
- [on_screen_text] 1. Full Songs
- [on_screen_text] 2. Interactive Sounds

PHASE 10: Trend #9 — Tech Bro Gradient

VERBATIM STREAM:

- [on_screen_text] Trend #9
- [on_screen_text] TECH BRO GRADIENT

- [on_screen_text] 1. Purple
- [on_screen_text] 1. Purples, Blues, Teals, Orange
- [on_screen_text] What cool trend can I jump on?
- [on_screen_text] What skills do I need to develop_